BRIDGING POST-PANDEMIC LEARNING GAPS IN INDIA

Closing the divide between disadvantaged and privileged learners—and improving learning for every child

THE CORE ISSUE
School reopening did not automatically restore lost learning or equalise access to support.

THE ANALYTICAL LENS
Learning recovery, socioeconomic inequality, foundational skills, teacher capacity and accountability.

THE SOLUTION
Assess learning, teach at the child's current level, target support and measure progress.

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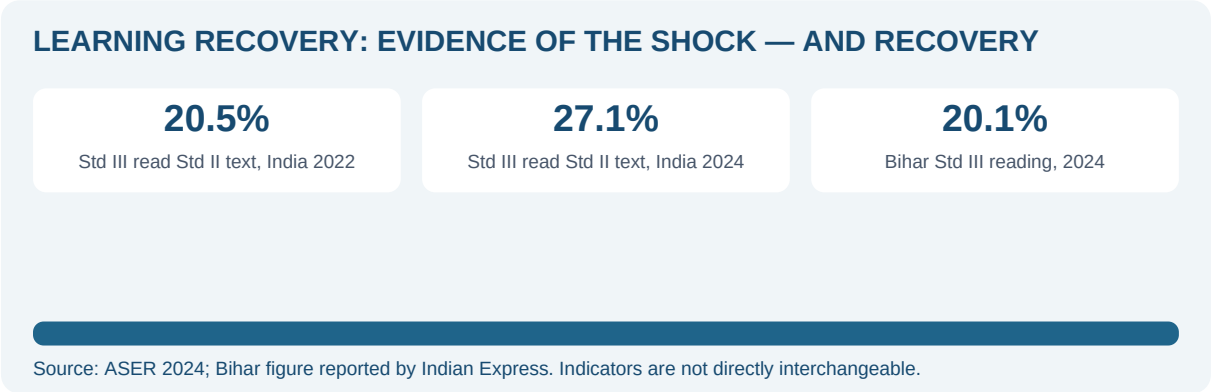
Evidence-led policy article for education leaders, school administrators, teacher organisations and governance-focused audiences.

Executive Summary

COVID-19 disrupted schooling, routines, peer interaction and access to adult support. The consequences were unequal: children from households with devices, stable connectivity, educated caregivers, quiet study space and paid tutoring could often continue learning more effectively than children without those resources. Yet the correct response is not to assume that every disadvantaged child has fallen behind or that every privileged child has learned well. The system must measure learning directly and respond to individual need.

India's ASER 2024 report provides an important national signal. Among rural children in Standard III, the share able to read a Standard II-level text fell from 27.3% in 2018 to 20.5% in 2022, then recovered to 27.1% in 2024. That is strong evidence of recovery in this indicator at the national level, but not proof that every state, grade, subject or social group has fully recovered. Bihar's Standard III reading figure was reported at 20.1% in 2024; basic arithmetic also improved, with 28.2% of Bihar's Standard III children able to do at least subtraction in the reported ASER comparison. These numbers underline both progress and the scale of foundational-learning work still required.



1. The problem is wider than pandemic learning loss

Three problems overlap. First, pre-existing inequality: children entered the pandemic with different levels of foundational literacy, numeracy, nutrition, language exposure and family support. Second, the shock: school closures interrupted teaching and reduced access to meals, routines, peer learning and school-based support. Third, uneven recovery: after reopening, children returned with widely different learning levels, while many classrooms still had to follow grade-level curricula and cover prescribed content.

This means that 'learning gap' should not be treated as a single average. It may involve a child's gap against grade expectations, a gap between socioeconomic groups, a gap between rural and urban access, or a gap between school systems. Policy must disaggregate data by grade, gender, disability, household disadvantage, school management and location wherever feasible.

2. What the evidence says—and what it does not say

ASER is a household-based assessment of rural children aged 5–16 and is particularly useful for understanding basic reading and arithmetic. It is not a census of all Indian students and does not by itself measure every subject, private-school advantage or all urban learners. National Achievement Survey and state assessments provide complementary evidence, but different tests and sampling designs should not be treated as interchangeable.

Global evidence from UNESCO, UNICEF and the World Bank found that learning losses were often larger among younger and poorer children and that remote-learning access was highly unequal. A 2024 global analysis using PISA data estimated an average decline of about 14% of a standard deviation—roughly seven months of learning—across the countries and contexts analysed. This is not an India-specific estimate and should not be presented as one.

The evidence also cautions against fatalism. A 2026 study of rural Tamil Nadu reported that measured learning deficits after reopening were recovered within about 20 months in its study population. This does not prove identical recovery elsewhere, but it shows that sustained, effective instruction can produce substantial gains.

3. Why the poor–elite divide can widen

• **Digital access:** access to a device is not the same as reliable connectivity, a suitable learning environment or effective teaching.

• **Private tutoring:** families able to pay may compensate for school disruption; families with limited income may be unable to do so.

• **Parental time and education:** caregivers with flexible work and stronger educational backgrounds may offer more academic support.

• **Language and learning materials:** children may struggle when instruction, home language and available resources do not align.

• **Disability and inclusion:** learners who need assistive materials, specialised support or accessible formats may face additional barriers.

• **Attendance, nutrition and wellbeing:** poverty-related pressures can affect concentration, regular attendance and readiness to learn.

4. A practical recovery framework for schools

Action 1 — Diagnose before prescribing. Conduct short, low-stakes baseline checks in reading, writing and mathematics. Group learners by demonstrated skill, not by social label or assumption. Repeat checks at intervals to identify who is progressing and who needs more support.

Action 2 — Teach at the child's current level. Use structured, level-appropriate instruction for a protected period each school day. Provide guided reading, number sense, problem-solving and frequent feedback. Bridge toward grade-level competencies rather than permanently lowering expectations.

Action 3 — Prioritise foundational literacy and numeracy. Foundational skills are gateways to science, social science and later learning. Integrate age-appropriate recovery into primary classes while also supporting adolescents who have unresolved reading and mathematics gaps.

Action 4 — Offer targeted tutoring without stigma. Provide small-group or peer-supported sessions during the school day where possible. Avoid creating a permanent 'weak child' label. Use flexible groups that change as learners progress.

Action 5 — Keep children present and connected. Track attendance, follow up with families when absences rise, and connect eligible children to nutrition, counselling, disability support and social protection. A child cannot benefit from teaching they do not receive.

Action 6 — Use technology as a supplement, not a substitute. Use offline-capable content, shared devices, radio or printed materials where relevant. Technology should support teacher-led instruction and feedback, not widen the gap between children with and without devices.

Action 7 — Protect teacher time and build capacity. Teachers need usable assessment tools, lesson resources, mentoring and professional collaboration. Reduce avoidable administrative burdens during recovery periods and avoid holding teachers solely responsible for structural inequalities.

5. The Bihar agenda: district-to-school implementation

For Bihar, the response should connect state priorities with district plans, school-level diagnosis and community partnership. District education teams can identify blocks and schools where foundational skills are weakest, then direct coaching, teaching materials and additional support accordingly. Schools should maintain simple progress dashboards that protect children's privacy and avoid public ranking or humiliation.

A practical implementation sequence is:

• **First 30 days:** conduct baseline assessments, map attendance and identify learners needing immediate support.

• **Days 31–90:** run structured catch-up lessons, coach teachers and hold short monthly reviews of progress.

• **Each term:** reassess the same core skills, review progress by group and adjust teaching support.

• **Each year:** publish a concise district report on learning growth, equity gaps, attendance and interventions—using comparable measures.

6. Teacher organisations as partners in recovery

Teacher associations can contribute beyond raising legitimate service and welfare issues. They can convene teachers to identify workable classroom strategies, document administrative barriers, promote peer mentoring and advocate for evidence-based workload and training policies. A constructive partnership among teachers, school leaders, families and government is more likely to produce sustained improvement than blame-driven approaches.

As State President of Bihar Pradesh Teacher Association, an educationist can advocate for three principles: **resources must reach the classroom; teachers must have the professional support to use them; and progress must be judged by children's learning, equity and wellbeing.** This complements, rather than replaces, the association's responsibility to represent teachers' professional interests.

7. Accountability: what should be measured?

Indicator	What it tells leaders
Reading and arithmetic growth	Whether children are learning more over time, not just attending school.
Progress by socioeconomic group	Whether the gap between disadvantaged and advantaged learners is narrowing.
Attendance and retention	Whether learners remain connected to school and receive instruction.
Teacher support and instructional time	Whether educators have the resources and time to deliver recovery.
Inclusion and wellbeing	Whether children with disabilities or other barriers receive appropriate support.
Cost per learner reached and improved	Whether programmes use public resources effectively and equitably.

8. A balanced conclusion: recovery is possible, but not automatic

The post-pandemic challenge is not simply to return to pre-2020 schooling. It is to build a more responsive system in which every child's learning level is visible, instruction responds to that level, and additional support reaches those who need it most. The national ASER trend shows that recovery can occur; Bihar's results show why foundational skills still require sustained attention. Neither averages nor slogans are enough: progress must be verified in classrooms and disaggregated to reveal who is being left behind.

Policy proposition: Establish a sustained Learning Recovery and Equity Compact for Bihar—baseline assessment, structured catch-up teaching, teacher coaching, family engagement, inclusion supports and transparent term-wise reporting. Make the central performance test the learning growth of the least-served children, while improving outcomes for all learners.

About the Author

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Data note: ASER figures refer to rural children and specific assessment indicators. Bihar's 20.1% Class III reading figure is reported in Indian Express' coverage of ASER 2024; it is not a measure of every student or school in Bihar. Global and state-specific evidence are labelled separately. Recovery recommendations are policy proposals, not claims that every intervention will have identical effects in all settings.